Interviewer guide: Years 5 and 6

This guide is reusable. Nothing is written on it: keep one in the room, in a folder or laminated. Ratings and notes for each student go on the **Interview sheet** (`forms/Interview_Sheet_Y5_Y6`).

About 12 minutes, 1:1. The interview is held **in English**. It has three jobs: to hear the student's spoken English (the speaking band), to get to know the student (interests, learning, wellbeing, **future plans and aspirations**), and to judge their **suitability** for the international programme. It opens with the Graded Sentence Reading Screen (3 to 4 minutes; start Level 4 for Year 5, Level 5 for Year 6; follow `shared/Sentence_Reading_Guide` and write the points on the Reading front sheet, `forms/Reading_Front_Sheet`).

How to ask. Smile, sit beside rather than opposite the child if you can, and start with something easy. Ask the main question first. If the child struggles, use the **easier** prompt (a yes or no, or a choice). If they answer easily, use the **stretch** prompt. Wait at least five seconds before rephrasing. Answers must be in English.

Pace of speech. Speak slowly and clearly: about 140 words a minute in Year 5 and about 155 in Year 6. Use the same pace for every candidate in the year group, and use it for the instructions and meaning questions of the sentence reading too. Do not rush: wait at least five seconds before rephrasing.

Safeguarding. Keep the door open or another adult present. If a child tells you something that worries you about their safety or wellbeing, do not promise to keep it secret; listen, write down their words, and pass it to the Designated Safeguarding Lead the same day.

1. Questions (8 minutes)

Choose about two questions from each block. On the Interview sheet, write short notes under "Key things the student said": what they said, and how they said it.

Block	Main question	Easier	Stretch
Warm-up	Tell me about yourself and your family.	What is your name? Do you have a brother or sister?	What do you like doing together as a family?
	What did you do last weekend?	Did you go out or stay at home?	What was the best part, and why?
School and learning	Tell me about your school now.	Do you like your school? What is your favourite subject?	What is one thing you would change about it?
	What do you find hard at school? What do you do then?	Is maths easy or hard for you?	Tell me about a time you learnt something hard.
	How do you learn English now?	Do you have English lessons? Do you read English books?	What helps you remember new words?
	How do you feel about having all your lessons in English?	Are you worried, excited, or both?	What do you think will be hardest?
Interests	What do you like to do after school and at weekends?	Do you like sport, music, art or games?	What are you best at, and how did you get good at it?
	Tell me about a book, film or game you like.	Do you like reading?	Why do you like it? Who would you recommend it to?
	How many classes or tutoring sessions do you have after school?	Do you have classes at the weekend?	How do you feel about it?
Friends and feelings	Tell me about your friends.	Do you have a best friend?	What makes someone a good friend?
	What do you do when you feel sad or worried?	Who do you talk to?	
	How do you feel about starting a new school?	Are you happy, nervous, or both?	What would help you settle in?

Block	Main question	Easier	Stretch
Future plans and aspirations	What would you like to be when you grow up? Why?	Do you have a dream job?	What do you need to learn to do that job?
	Is there a place in the world you would like to visit or live in?	China or another country?	What do you think it would be like?
	Why do you want to come to our school?	Is it your idea or your parents' idea?	What do you hope to learn here?
Values (choose one)	Your friend breaks a classmate's pencil and says nothing. What do you do?	Is that OK?	Why?
	A new student cannot speak your language and sits alone. What do you do?	Would you play with them?	How could you help them?
Questions for us	What would you like to ask me about the school?	Do you have any questions?	

2. Speaking band

Choose the band that fits best, for a child of this age, and tick it on the Interview sheet. Rate **listening in conversation** with the same letters. Pronunciation features of a speaker of Chinese do not lower the band if the child is easy to understand.

Band	What you hear
A New to English	Little or no spoken English, or single words and memorised phrases. Relies on Chinese, gesture or silence. Understands very little unless supported with pictures or gesture.
B Early acquisition	Short answers and simple memorised sentences about familiar things (family, school, likes). Frequent errors. Needs the easier prompts. Understands slow, simple questions.
C Developing competence	Answers most main questions with short connected sentences ("because", "and then", "but"). Errors are frequent but meaning is usually clear. Everyday vocabulary.
D Competent	Talks easily and at some length, explains and gives examples, manages most stretch prompts. Occasional errors that rarely affect meaning.
E Fluent	Speaks as fluently and accurately as a fluent English speaker of the same age.

3. Suitability

Rate each strand on the Interview sheet from what you saw and heard: **1** Concern, **2** Some concern, **3** Good, **4** Strong. Write the evidence: a short quotation or what you saw.

Strand	What strong looks like at this age
Attitude to learning and resilience	Keen to learn, has a go, keeps trying when work is hard
Curiosity and engagement	Asks questions, shows interest, enjoys talking about ideas
Social and emotional readiness	Settles with a new adult, talks about friends, manages nerves, ready for a new school
Independence and self-management	Follows instructions, looks after belongings, can work alone for a short time, will ask for help
Values and conduct	Kind, honest and polite in the interview and the values question
Readiness for English-medium learning	Happy to try speaking English even with mistakes, interested in learning English

Boarding readiness (only if the child will board): independence with daily routines, sleep, homesickness, experience of being away from home. Rate it on the Interview sheet in the same way.

4. Anything to follow up

Tick any that apply on the Interview sheet, and add a note:

- Possible special educational need or disability (for example reading, attention, speech, hearing, vision, coordination)
- Wellbeing (for example anxiety, very heavy after-school workload, sleep)
- Safeguarding (passed to the Designated Safeguarding Lead the same day)
- Medical or dietary

Receiving homeroom teacher (optional). If the child's likely homeroom teacher meets them, they note first impressions and what the child would need in the first weeks (for example a buddy, a picture word book, seating near the teacher) on the Interview sheet.

To finish. On the Interview sheet, write your comment for the final mark sheet (strengths, concerns, support), and sign and date it.